

From Philadelphia to Nat Turner; Shadrack Bassett's African Hymn Inspires an Uprising

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Article Text

Almost all liberation movements have a song that inspires people and turns rooms where it is sung into spirit filled spaces. In 1830s Virginia, *The African Hymn*, created by a Philadelphia based AME preacher Shadrack Bassett was *that* song.

On August 21, 1831, Nat Turner, an enslaved preacher and visionary in Virginia led a group of 70 enslaved people to rise up and fight for their freedom.

We see Nat Turner's uprising as an important galvanizing action. It made visible the strength of what was already an active transatlantic movement for emancipation led by Black people and including all oppressed people, ignited by the Haitian Revolution.

Leaders from Philadelphia were an important part of that movement.

This is a story that shows us one example of how.

From Bishop Allen to Rev. Shadrack Bassett to Nat Turner

Bishop Allen Sends Rev. Shadrack Bassett on a Mission

This story starts when Bishop Richard Allen traveled to Baltimore for the 1817 AME annual conference. Bishop Allen was building a core of itinerant preachers - men who would travel on foot to teach the gospel, build community and eventually build churches (Handy, 28). Note that this job later extended to women by the 1830s, thanks to Reverend Jerena Lee.

Bishop Allen ordained Shadrack Bassett at this conference and assigned him to Maryland's Eastern Shore.

Allen's preacher corp did more than build churches. They organized communities. They bought free and enslaved peoples together. And because of their communication back to the mother church in Philadelphia, their presence extended a network of communication, both verbal and written. Written materials were especially important. Historian Nathan Jeremie-Brink argues that "the distribution of print materials...was essential in supporting African American resistance" (Jeremie-Brink, 4),

The transatlantic emancipation movement was greatly facilitated by these networks of both free and enslaved Black and Indigenous people, organized around benevolent and aligned leadership, and with privacy and stability of physical church buildings. And almost all AME churches became underground railroad stops - sort of like local offices of the movement.

Before Rev. Bassett had a church building, he was well known for standing on top of an ox-cart to preach on Sundays at the corner of Hanson and South in Easton, Md. But when it was time to move into a building, he had a vision that led to the correct site to build the church.

He was motivated by a verse in a hymn "To dwell I'm determined on that happy ground" and while singing, he pointed to a spot of land and the people felt that he was telling them to build the church on that spot, which they did.

That church still stands today - nearly 200 years old.

Morgan State Professor Dale Green has been instrumental in documenting the history of The Hill Community in Easton.

Mission Accomplished, Shadrack Bassett is Sent to Preach in Virginia

In the late 1820s, Rev. Bassett was sent to preach in Virginia.

White authorities quickly learned that Rev. Bassett was preaching a theology that focused on liberation. Rev. Bassett's "emancipatory interpretation of the biblical narrative" got him ***barred from preaching*** by slavery supporting authorities (Callahan, 45).

In 1830, Rev. Bassett wrote *The African Hymn*.

We don't have the original music for the *The African Hymn*, but we do know it had *power*.

The authors of *Songs of Slavery and Emancipation* envisioned what the song may have sounded like.

[Full text of hymn preserved but not reproduced per IP guidelines]

Rev. Bassett's liberation theology, and *The African Hymn*, most likely inspired Nat Turner. (Callahan, 45)

Printed versions of *The African Hymn* were found in the confiscated papers owned by members of the Nat Turner uprising (Jeremie-Blink, 223).

The hymn itself was so powerful that it "struck terror in proslavery Virginians." The song "advanced a theological argument for Black liberation and a rhetoric of apocalyptic violence" common to related resistance movements (Jeremie-Blink, 224).

Black people were distributing the hymn clandestinely, singing the hymn and soaking in "God's promise of liberation" (Jeremie-Brink, 242). Even enslaved peoples miles away from the Nat Turner uprising were heard singing *The African Hymn* (Oates, 57).

Charity Bowery was an enslaved woman who lived through the Nat Turner uprising and described the post uprising environment in an 1839 interview with Lydia Maria Child. She told how Black people were not allowed to pray or sing hymns; that doing so would get them killed.

When asked by the interviewer to sing the songs that were prohibited, Bowery sang a song that referenced key refrains from *The African Hymn*. She said authorities feared Black people would organize because of singing such songs (Callahan, 60).

Finding Shadrack Bassett (or Maybe Shadrack Bassett Finds Us)

As part of Bethel Burying Ground work with Creative Philadelphia, researchers were studying people who may be buried at BBG. The display was featured at City Hall on the 2nd Floor outside the Mayor's office.

The author was looking specifically for home owners so that they could visit their homes and Rev. Bassett came up as a homeowner in the 1838 Census.

He did own his home on South 4th Street, just south of Christian, which he purchased in 1825.

So it appears that his home base was in Philadelphia even during the time he was in Virginia.

He lived in the home from 1825 to 1861. The author could not find him in the city directory after 1862 and has not been able to find a will or death certificate.

As confirmation that he was buried at BBG could not be made, Rev. Bassett was set aside for further study.

But then...

1838 Board Member Michelle Flamer and the author went to see the Dorsey collection at Penn State. The Dorsey Collection is the sibling to the Leon Gardiner collection at the Historical Society of Pennsylvania. Both collections were originally part of the one collection of the American Negro Historical Society.

Dorsey had kept a file on Rev. Bassett and when the author opened the folder, there he was—a portrait had emerged.

The author expressed surprise at finding such a high-quality portrait, noting how rare such images are of ancestors.

The author drew a connection between Rev. Bassett's biblical name and the story of Shadrach from the Book of Daniel—three men who refused to worship a false idol and were thrown in a fire but emerged unburned, protected by God.

Rev. Shadrack Bassett, a proud citizen of the 1838 Black Metropolis, has emerged from historical obscurity and brings *The African Hymn* back to contemporary awareness. The author suggests that perhaps someone could envision the lyrics set to modern music, so that this liberatory song could be sung and experienced again.

Sources

Note: Bassett's first name is spelled in various ways in official records: Shedrick, Shadric, Shadrack etc. The author uses Shadrack as found in Handy's AME history.

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Images

- AI imagining of Rev. Shadrack Bassett preaching in 1817 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_f2ef6aa0e28f45c7902216658823d092~mv2.png
- Bethel Burying Ground Display at City Hall — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_76d48126e3d74efea7e27766463752da~mv2.jpg
- Entry for Rev. Bassett in the 1838 PAS Census —

- https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_b645f41e501042e0907562badb16ed93~mv2.png
- Entry for Rev. Bassett in the Philadelphia Deed Book —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_7a669478ff294382903d2e1a258d5dd2~mv2.jpg
 - Shadrack Bassett Portrait, Courtesy Cheyney University and Penn State University —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_ca57548ff4bc430b8826e561cb5fb937~mv2.png
 - AI Reimagining of how Nat Turner's paper may have appeared —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_c7149e16efc444128818e9cdcf51e2fd~mv2.png
 - Nat Turner quote about Christ's crucifixion —
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